Homelessness in Oregon's Rogue Valley

Conditions, service gaps, and policy priorities

Homelessness in the Rogue Valley combines a shortage of affordable housing with serious gaps in shelter, health care, transportation, and support for people trying to regain stability. The regional picture is uneven: Jackson County has expanded its sheltered response, while Josephine County entered 2025 with an exceptionally high proportion of people living unsheltered and has since added shelter capacity whose operating stability remains uncertain. [1] [2] [3]

Report date: October 23, 2026
Scope: Jackson and Josephine counties, including Medford, Ashland, Grants Pass, smaller cities, and rural communities. Population comparisons use verified 2025 data; service and policy developments are updated through October 2026 where available.

Scale and measurement

The verified county baseline

Portland State University's *2025 Oregon Statewide Homelessness Estimates*, produced with Oregon Housing and Community Services and published in January 2026, provides a consistent county-level baseline. Its January 2025 figures identify **1,518 people experiencing sheltered or unsheltered homelessness across Jackson and Josephine counties**, including **744 living unsheltered.** [3]

January 2025 measure	Jackson County	Josephine County
People in shelters or transitional housing	740 [3]	34 [3]
People living unsheltered	421 [3]	323 [3]
Total counted	**1,161** [3]	**357** [3]
Unsheltered share	36.3% [3]	**90.5%** [3]
Shelter inventory reported for the count	794 beds [3]	34 beds [3]

These are 2025 figures, not an October 2026 census. In particular, Josephine County's baseline predates the opening of the 150-bed Parker's Place Village in 2026, so the table must not be read as a current inventory of its shelter capacity. [4] [3]

The shelter inventory includes emergency shelter, safe-haven, and transitional-housing categories; it does not mean every listed bed was vacant, available year-round, or appropriate

for every household. HUD also distinguishes people in permanent supportive housing from people currently experiencing homelessness. [5] [3]

Different county trajectories

Between 2023 and 2025, Jackson County's unsheltered count declined while its sheltered count increased; Josephine County experienced the opposite pattern. [3]

Measure	Jackson County, 2023 → 2025	Josephine County, 2023 → 2025
Unsheltered population	556 → 421, down 24% [3]	191 → 323, up 69% [3]
Sheltered population	587 → 740, up 26% [3]	58 → 34, down 41% [3]
Total population counted	1,143 → 1,161 [3]	249 → 357 [3]

The important distinction is that **Jackson County's reduction in unsheltered homelessness was not a comparable reduction in total homelessness:** substantially more people were sheltered, but the overall count remained slightly higher. Across both counties, the unsheltered totals were nearly unchanged—747 in 2023 and 744 in 2025—despite their sharply different local trajectories. [3]

Hidden homelessness

A point-in-time count captures one night, not everyone who experiences homelessness during a year, and generally excludes people temporarily sharing another household's housing because they have nowhere else to go. Rural geography, dispersed camps, and reluctance to engage with enumerators further complicate measurement. [6] [3]

School data reveal a broader problem: the PSU report recorded **1,647 students experiencing homelessness in Jackson County and 786 in Josephine County during the 2024–25 school year**. These figures use a broader educational definition, including qualifying doubled-up arrangements, and cannot be added to the January counts because the populations and reporting periods overlap. [3]

Housing and financial pressures

Affordability is central

ACCESS's 2025 Jackson County Community Needs Assessment identified housing as the leading community concern; 91% of responding stakeholders rated affordable rental housing a major concern. Its archival analysis also found that 43% of county households were below the ALICE threshold—a basic-needs budget measure that includes households earning above the federal poverty line but still unable to afford necessities. [2]

The assessment reported that approximately 46% of Jackson County renters paid at least 35% of their income toward housing, based on 2019–23 American Community Survey data. That is a historical affordability indicator, not a measurement of October 2026 asking rents. [2]

For someone with little financial cushion, a medical problem, reduced work hours, a vehicle repair, or a relationship breakdown can become a housing crisis. Local assessment participants also described benefit cliffs, move-in costs, and difficulties navigating assistance programs. [2]

Wildfire recovery remains relevant

The 2020 Almeda Fire continues to affect housing availability and affordability, according to ACCESS's 2025 assessment. Residents and providers reported that replacement construction does not necessarily replace housing at prices accessible to low-income households. [2]

Implication: Rebuilding units and restoring affordability are different objectives. Recovery should be evaluated partly by whether displaced and low-income households can actually obtain the replacement housing—not just by construction totals.

Eviction prevention matters

October 2026 reporting based on Eviction Lab data found elevated eviction filings across southwest Oregon, although that reporting covers a broader area than the Rogue Valley and measures court filings rather than completed evictions. It also identified rising costs and diminished rental-assistance resources as pressures on vulnerable tenants. [7]

Oregon Health Plan housing benefits offer one prevention mechanism: qualifying members may receive up to six months of rent assistance and other housing-related support. However, eligibility is restricted, rent assistance generally requires existing rental housing and a written agreement, and the benefits are not designed for emergencies. [8] [9]

Implication: Medicaid housing assistance is useful but cannot substitute for emergency eviction prevention, general rental subsidies, or housing options for people already living outside.

Everyday barriers to stability

Shelter must be usable

A listed bed is not necessarily a workable placement. Household composition, disability access, safety, admission procedures, and the availability of an appropriate setting all matter; local providers illustrate these differences, with OHRA's year-round shelter serving adults and ACCESS's Roxy offering a pet-friendly, referral-based setting for individuals and families. [10] [11]

OHRA prioritizes admission by vulnerability and provides private rooms and bathrooms, but requires an intake process and limits stays to six months. Its low-barrier designation means that completing addiction treatment or passing a background check is not required for admission; it does not mean immediate admission or unlimited capacity. [10]

For planning purposes, "available shelter" should therefore mean **an appropriate placement the particular person can actually enter**, rather than a nominal bed somewhere in the county.

Transportation and rural access

ACCESS's assessment identified transportation barriers affecting access to jobs, food, and health care, with particular concerns in rural communities such as Prospect, Butte Falls, Shady Cove, and the Applegate area. Fuel costs and vehicle repairs were substantial concerns among survey respondents.[2]

Rural homelessness can also be less visible: people may live alone or in small groups, in vehicles or RVs, or in inadequate structures far from services. National rural-health research identifies long distances, limited transit, clinician shortages, and poor broadband access as overlapping barriers; these findings provide context, not a Rogue Valley-specific prevalence estimate.[6]

Implication: A service concentrated in Medford or Grants Pass is not functionally accessible to everyone in the surrounding county. Outreach, transportation, and geographically distributed intake need to be treated as part of service capacity.

Documents and digital access

Community participants described complex paperwork, online-only applications, technology barriers, and caseworker turnover as obstacles to obtaining and maintaining assistance. OHRA's resource navigation explicitly includes help with identification, mail, benefits, and related essentials.[10] [2]

These administrative supports are not peripheral: they connect people to the applications, appointments, and documentation needed for housing and income assistance. Local providers' emphasis on resource navigation reflects that practical role.[12] [11]

Health and behavioral health

ACCESS's assessment documented concerns about mental-health access, dental care, prescription costs, provider shortages, and long waits; 75% of participating stakeholders rated mental-health services a major concern. Those findings describe community and service-system concerns, not the percentage of unhoused residents with a mental illness.[2]

Housing instability, substance-use disorders, disability, and mental illness can interact, but the reviewed local evidence does not support treating addiction or mental illness as a universal explanation for homelessness. The same assessment identifies housing affordability, transportation, benefit eligibility, and administrative barriers as major problems.[2]

A useful response must therefore provide both housing pathways and accessible care, rather than assuming that one service will resolve every person's circumstances.

Weather and environmental exposure

Cold, extreme heat, wildfire smoke, and inadequate access to protected indoor space are important regional planning concerns; Oregon public-health officials identify increasing climate hazards, including smoke preparedness work in Jackson and Josephine counties.

Ashland's severe-weather shelter program reflects the need for protection beyond ordinary overnight camping arrangements. [13] [14]

Recommended approach: Treat clean-air space, cooling, warming, drinking water, sanitation, and evacuation assistance as essential infrastructure, with clear activation criteria and transportation arrangements.

Groups requiring tailored support

Population	Relevant issue	Planning implication
Children and families	School data identify a much broader population than street counts alone reveal. [3]	Coordinate family housing assistance with district homeless-student liaisons.
Older adults and disabled people	Mobility limitations and chronic illness can make repeated packing and relocation especially difficult, as documented in the Grants Pass disability-rights litigation. Lawsuit record	Provide accessible shelter, storage, accommodations, and appropriate care connections.
Domestic-violence survivors	Josephine County's Women's Crisis Support Team provides safety planning, advocacy, and emergency shelter assistance. [15] [16]	Preserve confidential, survivor-specific pathways rather than relying exclusively on general shelter.
Rural residents	Distance and limited transportation compound service-access barriers. [2] [6]	Fund mobile outreach and transportation alongside centralized facilities.
People facing language or communication barriers	ACCESS participants identified language-access needs, including for immigrant and deaf or hard-of-hearing communities. [2]	Provide interpretation, accessible communication, and assisted applications.
People with criminal records	Providers identified employment barriers associated with criminal histories. [2]	Include legal assistance, employment support, and individualized housing navigation.

These groups overlap. Program design should accommodate the person's combined circumstances rather than require them to fit a single administrative category.

Local response and gaps

Medford and Jackson County

Medford has invested in a response that includes the Navigation Center, Urban Campground, motel-based shelter, transitional housing, and outreach. Its 2026–27 draft action plan also identifies proposed support for youth and family navigation, transitional housing, and legal services connected to the Navigation Center. [17] [18] [19]

ACCESS currently describes the Roxy as a low-barrier, pet-friendly shelter with 43 rooms, available through referral. Rogue Retreat provides additional shelter and housing pathways, while the Jackson County Continuum of Care coordinates participating organizations across the local response system. [20] [21] [11]

Medford reported that its surveyed illegal encampments declined from 186 in March 2023 to 13 in March 2026. **That is an encampment-management measure, not proof that the same proportion of people obtained housing**; the city's count tracks sites, whereas homelessness outcomes require tracking people and their destinations. Livability Team report [3]

Ashland

OHRA operates a year-round shelter and resource center at 2350 Ashland Street, providing resource navigation and other services to housed and unhoused residents. Its shelter operates continuously, but admission is prioritized and subject to availability. [12] [10]

Beginning September 28, 2026, OHRA took on management of Ashland's Dusk to Dawn—or Night Lawn—site at 1175 East Main Street under a six-month pilot scheduled through March 30, 2027. The city describes managed overnight resting, monitoring, resource connections, and planned site improvements. [22]

The city also maintains a separate severe-weather shelter site at 2200 Ashland Street. Published information includes the previous winter's operating arrangements, so **a past seasonal announcement should not be treated as confirmation that a shelter is open tonight.** [13] [22]

Grants Pass and Josephine County

Parker's Place Village substantially changed the county's shelter landscape in 2026, adding a project designed for 150 people in converted shipping containers. August reporting described final occupancy approvals still being completed as the shelter approached capacity. [4]

By October, however, its operating model faced significant uncertainty: the city alleged grant noncompliance, and reporting identified unresolved questions about ongoing expenses and service arrangements. On October 15, a new partnership with The Do Good Foundation took effect as the shelter's partnership with MINT ended. [1]

The $1.2 million city grant supported development, but October reporting described the absence of a dedicated operating budget and uncertainty over costs previously covered by MINT. **The central issue is therefore not merely creating beds, but reliably funding staffing, utilities, sanitation, security, and support services after construction.** [1]

Law and public-space concerns

The U.S. Supreme Court's June 2024 decision in *City of Grants Pass v. Johnson* held that enforcement of generally applicable public-camping laws does not, by itself, violate the Eighth Amendment's prohibition on cruel and unusual punishment. It did not decide that every camping restriction is lawful under every other legal framework. [23]

Oregon has a separate framework requiring objectively reasonable regulation of certain survival activities on public property, and disability-related obligations remain relevant. Disability Rights Oregon's subsequent Grants Pass litigation reached a settlement in August 2025, illustrating that the Supreme Court ruling did not end local legal disputes. Lawsuit and settlement record [24]

Residents, businesses, public-space users, and unhoused people all have legitimate interests in safety, sanitation, access, and predictable rules. The policy question is whether a particular intervention improves those conditions **and** leaves affected people with a realistic place to go.

A sound evaluation should distinguish:

- **Public-space outcomes:** Accessible sidewalks, usable parks, sanitation, and reduced hazards.
- **Human outcomes:** Appropriate shelter access, housing placements, health connections, and fewer returns to homelessness.
- **Displacement outcomes:** Movement to another block, jurisdiction, vehicle, or harder-to-reach location.

These are proposed evaluation categories; a decline in visible encampments alone cannot establish success across all three.

Policy priorities

The following recommendations are analytical judgments grounded in the documented regional gaps.

Stabilize existing capacity

Prioritize dependable operating agreements and budgets for existing shelters before counting proposed beds as usable capacity. Parker's Place demonstrates the risk of completing a capital project without a durable arrangement for essential operations and services. [1]

Contracts should specify accessible capacity, staffing, sanitation, admission practices, incident response, service responsibilities, and continuity plans if an operator withdraws.

Prevent avoidable housing loss

Expand rapid, flexible help for rental arrears, utilities, deposits, and legal assistance. OHP housing benefits should be integrated into that response, but their eligibility limits and processing requirements make a separate emergency prevention pathway necessary. [9] [8]

Recommended performance measures include time from request to assistance, housing retained after six and twelve months, and reasons eligible households could not be served.

Match housing to need

Develop a mix of deeply affordable rentals, rental assistance, and permanent supportive housing with ongoing services. Research reviews find strong evidence that Housing First approaches improve housing stability, while effects on mental-health and substance-use outcomes are more mixed; housing is a platform for care, not a guarantee that every clinical problem resolves. [25] [26]

The implication is to avoid a false choice between "housing" and "treatment." Different people need different combinations, intensity, and duration of support.

Make services reachable

Fund transportation, mobile outreach, document replacement, phone access, mail, and assisted applications as part of the housing response. Local assessment findings identify precisely these kinds of access and navigation barriers.[10] [2]

For rural communities, evaluate access by whether someone can complete the trip and intake process—not merely whether a program exists somewhere in the county.

Publish meaningful outcomes

Adopt a regional dashboard that separates one-night counts, annual service users, shelter capacity, actual occupancy, housing placements, and public-space enforcement. These measures answer different questions and should not be presented interchangeably.[5] [3]

Recommended indicators include:

- First-time homelessness and returns to homelessness
- Time from referral to appropriate shelter
- Shelter denials and their reasons
- Exits to permanent housing and housing retention
- Rural travel and service-access barriers
- Family and student housing instability
- Public-space conditions alongside destinations after displacement

Compensated participation by people with lived experience should inform both dashboard design and program evaluation.

Practical access points

These are starting points, not guarantees of a bed or financial assistance. Confirm current hours, eligibility, intake procedures, and availability before traveling.

Need or area	Starting point
Jackson County outreach and shelter navigation	**ACCESS: 541-200-3684.** Its published outreach information includes shelter referrals and resource navigation. [11]
Ashland resource navigation	**OHRA: 541-631-2235**, 2350 Ashland Street; help includes shelter intake, identification, mail, and housing-related resources. [10]
Rogue Retreat programs	**541-499-0880**; contact the organization for current program and application information. [27] [20]
Josephine County community-action assistance	**UCAN: 800-301-8226**; request information about current housing and basic-needs assistance. [28] [29]
Josephine County domestic-violence crisis support	**Women's Crisis Support Team: 541-479-9349**, available 24/7. [16]
OHP housing benefits	Contact the member's health plan or coordinated care organization; eligibility restrictions apply, and benefits are not emergency assistance. [8] [9]

Need or area	Starting point
Children lacking stable housing	Ask the school district for its homeless-student liaison; educational eligibility includes circumstances beyond street homelessness. [3]

Evidence limitations

The most important limitation is timing: this report uses verified 2025 county counts alongside 2026 operational developments, not a verified region-wide October 2026 population estimate. New shelter capacity and operating changes mean current conditions can differ substantially from the baseline. [1] [3]

ACCESS's assessment adds valuable resident and provider perspectives, but its 602 valid community surveys and 178 valid stakeholder surveys were not a random sample of the entire county. The assessment acknowledges uneven participation, digital-access barriers, and limited turnout in some communities, so its survey percentages should not be generalized to all residents or all unhoused people. [2]

The available evidence also does not establish a current Rogue Valley-wide total for unmet shelter demand, deaths among unhoused people, or housing destinations following every encampment removal. Those remain priority questions for regional data collection rather than gaps that can responsibly be filled with assumptions.

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